

THE WAY

Companion Handbook

A practical guide to walking the Way, belonging to the Assembly, and living safely in a House of Prayer

Version 1.0 | September 20, 2026

Founding edition for pilot community use

Truth precedes the institution. Conscience is never surrendered. Authority is entrusted and limited.

Welcome

The Way is not primarily something you join. It is a path you may choose to walk. A Companion is simply a person who chooses to walk that path with others while retaining conscience, outside relationships, and the freedom to leave.

In one sentence: We are Companions of the Way. Together we are the Assembly. We gather in Houses of Prayer for prayer, study, fellowship, discernment, and service - seeking truth without surrendering conscience.

1. Start here: the whole in plain language

Term	What it means
the Way	The religious path of seeking truth and living in response to it.
Companion	A person who freely walks the Way with others.
the Assembly	The wider religious community.
House of Prayer	A local community of the Assembly; it need not own a building.
Gathering	A specific meeting for prayer, study, service, fellowship, or discernment.
Teacher	A person trusted to teach within demonstrated competence.
Minister	A person commissioned for defined religious/pastoral functions.
Steward	A person entrusted with defined operational or resource responsibilities.
Board of Directors	The civil governing board of the nonprofit corporation; not the same thing as the Assembly.

2. You can participate before you belong

A person may attend public gatherings, study, pray, ask questions, join service projects, eat with the community, disagree, or remain a long-term participant without becoming a Companion. No six-month visitor, lifelong guest, or curious neighbor should be pressured into religious identification.

- You do not need to donate to attend.
- You do not need to disclose private information to prove sincerity.
- You do not need to stop reading critics or participating in outside relationships.
- You do not need to adopt every provisional teaching.
- You may leave at any time.

3. Becoming a Companion

Ordinarily, become familiar enough with the Way to understand its rights, core practices, teaching-status system, House structure, safeguarding route, and the fact that major metaphysical questions remain open. Then, if you freely choose, make the Companion Commitment publicly, privately, or in writing.

The Companion Commitment

I choose freely to walk the Way in companionship with others.

I will seek truth with humility and practice prayer, study, ethical action, service, and discernment according to conscience and capacity.

I will distinguish testimony from interpretation, authority from truth, and conviction from coercive command.

I will not surrender my conscience to a leader, office, council, or institution, nor demand that another person surrender conscience to me.

I will respect the freedom of others to question, disagree, seek outside counsel, participate, or depart.

I will support safeguarding, financial integrity, honest inquiry, accountability, and repair when harm occurs.

I understand that I may cease identifying as a Companion at any time without permission, penalty, shunning, or loss of ordinary human relationships.

The Commitment is religious rather than contractual. It does not transfer property, waive legal rights, create a lifetime vow, create statutory corporate membership, or authorize leaders to control your personal decisions.

4. Your rights

- Freedom to believe, doubt, question, disagree, reinterpret, or decline a religious claim.
- Freedom to read critics, consult other traditions, seek independent legal/medical/financial/mental-health advice, and maintain outside relationships.
- Freedom to attend public gatherings without becoming a Companion.
- Freedom to decline prayer forms, rites, fasting, counseling, donation requests, volunteer service, housing arrangements, or ministry roles.
- Freedom to leave immediately upon clear communication, without permission, spiritual release, confession, payment, nondisparagement agreement, or doctrinal recantation.
- Protection from shunning directives, public humiliation, doxxing, retaliatory disclosure, threats of supernatural catastrophe, or adverse action motivated by criticism or protected reporting.
- Access to safeguarding, complaint, independent investigation, appeal, and non-retaliation processes.
- Protection of children and vulnerable persons under applicable law and organizational safeguarding standards.
- Equal human dignity regardless of membership, office, wealth, sex, family status, certainty, disability, ethnicity, nationality, prior religion, criticism, or departure.

What happens if you disagree?

Ordinary disagreement is not misconduct. A Companion may criticize a teaching, oppose a leader, decline a rite, reject a Minister's advice, consult another religion, or advocate revision. Conduct rules may still address harassment, violence, discrimination, fraud, retaliation, or other real harms, but disagreement itself is not a punishable offense.

5. Everyday practice

The Way currently uses a sevenfold practice rather than a long checklist of mandatory observances.

Practice	Try this in ordinary life
Attention	Create regular moments of stillness, observation, and honest awareness.
Prayer	Speak, listen, give thanks, lament, ask, praise, or sit in reverent silence according to conscience.
Study	Read primary sources, history, scholarship, and competing interpretations.
Discernment	Test motives, claims, choices, and proposed actions rather than treating impulse as revelation.
Ethical Practice	Tell the truth, honor consent, restrain harm, keep commitments, repair wrongdoing, and seek justice.
Service	Help people and communities without making aid conditional on religious loyalty.
Companionship	Share life, hospitality, encouragement, correction, and care with others without ownership.

A flexible rhythm

- Daily: some form of attention/prayer and ethical reflection when practicable.
- Weekly: some form of communal gathering, rest, study, fellowship, or service.
- Periodic: service, Common Table/fellowship, extended study, retreat, remembrance, or discernment.
- Seasonal/annual: practices may be piloted, reviewed, and revised rather than imposed permanently from the beginning.

6. What happens at a House of Prayer

A healthy House should feel recognizably religious without becoming a controlled environment. It should make room for devotion and serious inquiry at the same time.

Gathering	What to expect
Prayer	Welcome, silence/prayer, readings/reflection, intercession, closing; music or spontaneous prayer may be included.
Study	Primary source, context, competing interpretations, discussion, and explicit uncertainty.
Service	A real community need addressed voluntarily without conversion requirements.
Fellowship / Common Table	Shared food or relationship time without status seating or

Gathering	What to expect
	insider privilege.
Discernment	A clearly stated question, conflict disclosure, evidence and arguments, reflection, recorded outcome, and acknowledged uncertainty.

What should never happen at a Gathering

- Sleep deprivation, prolonged exhaustion, forced fasting, forced confession, humiliation, intimidation, deceptive recruitment, restricted exit, confiscation of property/devices, or social isolation to produce commitment.
- Public spiritual commands over another adult's marriage, sexuality, healthcare, finances, residence, employment, education, or family relationships.
- Pressure to prove devotion through money, labor, secrecy, loyalty to a leader, or separation from outsiders.

7. How teaching works

The Way does not treat every religious statement as equally certain. Teachers should distinguish evidence, historical reconstruction, interpretation, theology, hope, symbolism, and institutional decision.

Label	What it means for you
Established	The Assembly considers the defined claim strongly supported, though still revisable.
Well-Supported	Best current conclusion, but important uncertainty remains.
Provisional	Useful working conclusion or practice under review.
Permitted Interpretation	You may hold it; the Assembly does not require it.
Open Question	The Assembly does not presently know enough to settle it.
Rejected as Harmful or Unsupported	It may be studied, but cannot be used as an accepted basis for coercion or harm.

Examples of current open questions

- The precise metaphysical nature of God/ultimate reality.
- Ontological Christology, Trinity, atonement mechanisms, and resurrection metaphysics.
- The divine authorship of the Qur'an and finality of Muhammad's prophethood.
- Buddhist rebirth, nirvana metaphysics, and final implications of non-self.
- Immortal soul, resurrection, rebirth, heaven/hell, annihilation, universal reconciliation, and other afterlife models.
- Final marriage theology, ordination theology, comprehensive sacred calendar, and formal doctrine of dual religious belonging.

8. Family, intimate life, and personal decisions

The founding baseline is intentionally stronger on consent and safety than on unresolved metaphysical claims about family form.

- Meaningful consent, capacity, non-exploitation, honesty, safeguarding, and responsibility to dependents are required.
- Spiritual status, prophecy, money, employment, housing, immigration status, dependency, or threatened exclusion may not be used to obtain sexual or marital compliance.
- No person gains spiritual rank by marrying, remaining single, having children, remaining childless, or conforming to a leader's preferred family form.
- Pastoral care may help you examine values and safety; it may not compel marriage, divorce, reconciliation, reproduction, abstinence from lawful adult relationships, or disclosure of intimate facts merely to prove loyalty.

9. Suffering, healing, and death

- You should not be told that suffering proves divine punishment, karmic desert, weak faith, or spiritual inferiority.
- Prayer for healing is allowed; refusing or seeking medical/mental-health treatment is never a test of faith.
- Funerals and memorials should honor the dead, support mourners, and distinguish hope from certainty.
- No Minister may claim certain knowledge of another person's final destiny merely by office.

10. Ministers, Teachers, Stewards, and Elders

Leadership in the Way is a function, not a superior species of person. You may ask what authority a person actually has. Their written role, commission, policy, or corporate delegation should answer the question.

- A Teacher can be corrected.
- A Minister can be investigated, suspended, or removed.
- A Steward does not own what they administer.
- An Elder, if the role is adopted, does not automatically control money, discipline, doctrine, or revelation.
- The founder is subject to the same complaint, conflict, compensation, safeguarding, and investigation systems as other leaders.

11. Money, work, housing, and charitable help

- Giving is voluntary. No donation purchases spiritual standing, office, healing, revelation, protection, or special access.
- Employment is employment, not proof of spiritual loyalty. Wages, benefits, supervision, and discipline should follow ordinary lawful processes.

- Housing, if the Way later provides it, may not be used to trap people in religious participation or silence criticism.
- Charitable assistance is based on charitable purpose and need, not religious conformity, donation history, silence, or membership.

12. Safeguarding, complaints, and retaliation

If something is unsafe, abusive, coercive, fraudulent, or retaliatory, spiritual reconciliation does not replace ordinary reporting and protection. Child abuse/neglect and other mandatory-reporting matters must be handled under applicable law before internal spiritual processes.

- Use the normal House contact for ordinary concerns when appropriate.
- Use the independent integrity/safeguarding channel when leadership is implicated or independence is needed.
- Anonymous reports may be accepted.
- An allegation that cannot be substantiated is not automatically a bad-faith allegation.
- Retaliation for reporting, witnessing, criticizing, declining participation, or leaving is prohibited.

13. Leaving - and returning

A clear statement that you no longer identify as a Companion is enough. No permission, exit interview, confession, payment, doctrinal recantation, nondisparagement promise, or spiritual release is required.

- Friends and relatives are not instructed to shun you.
- Confidential pastoral information remains protected after departure.
- You may criticize the Way publicly.
- Ordinary property, wages, benefits, deposits, records, and contractual rights are handled under ordinary law, not religious standing.
- You may later return if you freely wish; return cannot be conditioned on denying legitimate criticism or past experience.

14. A practical first 90 days

Period	Suggested approach
Weeks 1-4	Attend different gathering types; read the Constitution and Teaching & Practice Baseline; ask difficult questions; keep outside relationships normal.
Weeks 5-8	Try a personal rhythm of attention, prayer, study, service, and companionship; participate in a service activity; learn the complaint/safeguarding route.
Weeks 9-12	Decide whether the Companion identity honestly describes your relationship to the Way. If yes, make the Commitment in a manner meaningful to you. If no, continue participating or leave without penalty.

15. Glossary

Term	Short definition
Encounter	A reported experience interpreted as contact with or awareness of transcendent reality.
Testimony	An account of an encounter, conviction, event, or practice.
Interpretation	The human act of assigning meaning to testimony, text, event, or experience.
Teaching	A proposition or practice currently taught by the Assembly.
Doctrine	A formally adopted teaching with defined status and implications.
Discernment	Testing claims, motives, choices, and interpretations individually and communally.
Commissioning	Formal authorization for a defined ministry or service function.
Library of Witnesses	The open research corpus studied by the Way; inclusion does not mean canonization or endorsement.
Rule of Life	A voluntary, adaptable pattern of practice; never a coercive surveillance code.
Former Companion	A person who no longer identifies as a Companion and retains ordinary dignity, relationships, and rights.

16. The maturity test

A healthy Way is not measured by how difficult it is to leave or how dependent people become on its leaders. It is measured by whether people grow in honesty, compassion, discernment, responsibility, freedom from manipulation, service, and capacity to seek truth - and whether the community can survive correction.

Remember: You are a Companion, not property of the Assembly. A Minister can serve you without owning your conscience. A House can become home without becoming a cage.